There was Once a Little Girl – A Collection

By Jessica Jocelyn

(PF, Pg 3) Welcome to childhood,
where the monsters under your bed
are the least of your problems.
Where the real ones sleep in the next room,
and you learn to breathe more quietly
when they're angry.
Where your tears are unwelcome,
and 'I love you' comes with conditions.
Where you mistake fear for respect
and silence for safety.

Welcome to childhood,
where you never meet the child
you were supposed to be.

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INTRODUCTION

From the trembling perspective of a daughter who wanted nothing more than to be loved -- these poems breathe in the quiet terror of growing up too carefully; of learning when to speak, when to disappear, and how to make yourself small enough to survive your mother's pain.

There was Once a Little Girl – A Collection of poems from Paper Flowers and Stars at Last by Jessica Jocelyn

(PF, Pg 4) There was once a little girl
made of paper
raised by a mother with scissor hands.

Everyone was quick to misunderstand her.

They didn't know love and hate
felt the same to her.
They didn't know what it was like
to run to be held
only to be left in shreds.

So they labeled her as the bad seed.
Her cries for help were mislabeled
as being difficulty.

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And so
She drifted through life like a ghost
in a body that remembered
every time she was torn
and told it was love.

(SAL, Pg 75) if you ask me about my mom,
I will just shrug and say we don't talk.

But if you look into my eyes,

They will tell you that I never outgrew the little girl who always wanted her mother. When my heart broke for the first time, when I had a positive pregnancy test . .

I always wanted her.

I wanted her hand to be there on my arm, to tell me she knew what it felt like and that I would make it to better days.

I could never outrun the little girl who cried out for her until my lungs collapsed, until my knees bled from being on the ground for so long.

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They will tell you that inside,
I will never stop being the little girl who reaches out for her.

(PF) I wasn't just the eldest daughter.
I was the shield,
the mouthpiece,
the stand-in mother.

I wore those roles so well that
they forgot I was a child.
And eventually
so did I.

(PF) How to be good to your mother:

Mirror her pain but don't outshine it
try to heal her
try to save her
carry her wounds like heirlooms
smile pretty for the pictures
let her take credit
never say what really happened
protect her reputation
shrink when she gets loud

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thank her for the bare minimum
become the daughter she could love.

(PF, Pg 6) She loved me once.
When I was warm and brand new,
smooth on her chest.
Smelling of all her hopes and dreams.

She loved me sometimes.
When I started to grow,
I brought a new fear into her heart --
the one where I might leave someday.

She loved me when I wasn't a mirror.
When she could look at me
and not see the girl she never got to be.

(PF) If I run far enough,
will I still be someone's daughter?
Will my name be spoken in whispers,
Or worse, not spoken at all?

If I stay away long enough,
can I be erased by time?

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Can I slip between the cracks so far
that I void the blood that ties us?

I'm not sure what it feels like to be loved,
but I don't think it's supposed to feel like this.
I don't think my feet should be scarred
from walking on eggshells.

(PF) I can't bleed in the name of
'Honor your parents.'
I can't disappear in the name of
'That never happened.'
I can't keep dying in the name of
'You're being dramatic.'

(PF) They say it's in my blood,
that I was born this way.
I was wired wrong,
fused from my mother's sadness
and my father's violence.

But I remember the nights
she would scream at the walls
that never gave her peace.
the way I watched

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instead of slept,
memorizing her storms
so I'd know how to survive mine.

They say it's nature,
But I know it was nurture too.

How can a child raised in fire
not grow flames of their own?

(SAL) my mother's rage bounced off the walls
in our house
and hid in all the dark corners.

It would fester in the walls
and start to eat them like mold.

She was always angry
but there was never a fire in her yes,
only a dark, cold, emptiness

(PF) my mother
was judge, jury and executioner.

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Once you were sentenced,
you were rotten flesh
decaying under six feet of dirt.

No one could hear you,
no one could smell you,
no one could even say your name.

To acknowledge your existence
would mean you were against her.

And if you went against her,
she could make you disappear.

(PF) In other life and time,
I could save my mother.
I'd pull her from the fire
before it reached her heart,
teach her that softness isn't weakness.
that love doesn't have to hurt to be real.

I'd braid her hair and tell her she's safe,
hold her while she cries for the childhood she lost.

I'd rewrite the story before it wrote her,
before she wrote me with the same ink.

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Maybe then,
we could have found each other whole.

(PF) Mom, Can I please be little again?
Undo the years
that taught me my voice never mattered.

Mom, just this once,
sing me to sleep with a lullaby
and maybe I'll wake up in
a world where your love
is louder than your pain.

(SAL) my mother placed her pain in my palm and
clasped her hands around mine.

'this was given to me by my mother. it was a
gift and now I'm giving it to you. to be a
woman is to inherit pain.'

I carried that pain with me for many years.
one day, I was rocking my brand-new baby
daughter to sleep. her face on my chest, being
soothed by the sound of my heartbeat.

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I took the pain from my pocket and swallowed
it whole. I could feel it burning my stomach.

I will gladly feel the pain for the rest of my life
if it means I can't ever give it to my daughter.

I will never know what it is like to have my
mother protect me.

but my daughter will.

(SAL) yes, you are still my mother,
and you always will be.

But, I've always been your daughter.

I can forgive that you didn't know
how to love me.
but, I can't forget that you didn't even
want to learn how.

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